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IN PLAIN SIGHT

By Jennifer Doloski

Adapted from Harriet Jacobs' *Incidents In The Life of a Slave Girl*

The publisher asks performers to please credit both authors.

Introduction:

Harriet Jacobs, known as Linda Brent in her writings, escaped slavery in 1835. She spent the next seven years hiding in plain sight, in the attic space of a shed on her grandmother's property. Her children having been purchased by their free, white father and given to the care of her grandmother only days after her escape – she alternately joyed and agonized as she listened to them grow up, unaware of her presence. After her escape to the northern, free states, hidden on a cargo vessel, it would be nearly a year before she would have both of her children with her again. Adapted by Jennifer Doloski from Incidents In The Life of a Slave Girl by Harriet Jacobs.

Note:

Though the narrator is Linda, her parts spoken to the audience are noted as Narrator, while her conversations with other characters are noted as Linda.

NARRATOR: It had been several weeks since I had left my master's, and I could no longer safely stay in the home where I had been hidden. Dr. Flint's hunt for me had been relentless. Too many times, already, I had been nearly discovered. I knew my presence must be a source of perpetual anxiety to my kind benefactress, herself a slaveholder. During this time, my friends had laid many plans for my escape.

LINDA: Betty, I must leave here tonight.

BETTY: Do as you tink best, poor chile.

LINDA: Oh, Betty! I don't know how to tell you, to thank you. . .

BETTY: I don't want no tanks, honey. I'se glad I could help you, and I hope de good Lord vill open de path for you.

NARRATOR: Betty, the maid who had been concealing me, gave me a sailor's uniform to wear and sent me out the back door after dark. At the gate I found Peter, a young colored man, waiting for me. I had known him for years. He had been an apprentice to my father and had always borne a good character. I was not afraid to trust him. Betty bade me a hurried goodbye,

BETTY: I'se so glad you is gwine to free parts! Don't forget ole Betty. P'raps I'll come 'long by and by.

PETER: Take courage, Linda. I've got a dagger, and no man shall take you from me, unless he passes over my dead body.

NARRATOR: It was a long time since I had taken a walk out of doors, and the fresh air revived me. It was also pleasant to hear a human voice speaking to me above a whisper. I passed several people whom I knew, but they did not recognize me in my disguise. I prayed internally that, for Peter's sake, as well as my own, nothing might occur to bring out his dagger.

LINDA: Where are we going?

PETER: To Aunt Marthy's.

NARRATOR: Aunt Marthy was my grandmother. I could not imagine how it was possible to hide me in her house, every nook and corner of which was known to Dr. Flint.

LINDA: Peter, no! I cannot hide there, not even for a night!

PETER: Linda, you just wait and see. Your Uncle Philip, he's got a place prepared for you. You just wait and see.

NARRATOR: We continued boldly through the streets, to my grandmother's. I wore my sailor's clothes, and passed several people whom I knew. The father of my children came so near that I brushed against his arm; but he had no idea who it was.

PETER: You must make the most of this walk, for you may not have another very soon.

NARRATOR: I thought his voice sounded sad. It was kind of him to conceal from me what a dismal hole was to be my home for a long, long time.

LINDA: (arms outstretched) Grandmother!

GRANDMOTHER: Hush! You'll wake the children.

LINDA: Can I see them?

GRANDMOTHER: I said hush! No. Climb on up now.

LINDA: But. . .

PETER: Linda. You know they can't know you are here.

LINDA: I won't wake them. I just want to gaze upon them. Please.

PETER: Up you go now.

NARRATOR: A small shed had been added to my grandmother's house years ago. Some boards were laid across the joists at the top, and between these boards and the roof was a very small garret, never occupied by anything but rats and mice. It was a pent roof, covered with nothing but shingles, according to the southern custom for such buildings. The garret was only nine feet long and seven wide. The highest part was three feet high and sloped down abruptly. There was no admission for either light or air. My Uncle Phillip, who was a carpenter, had very skillfully made a concealed trapdoor, which communicated with the storeroom. The storeroom opened upon a piazza. The air was stifling, the darkness total. A bed had been spread on the floor. I could sleep quite comfortably on one side; but the slope was so sudden that I could not turn on the other without hitting the roof. The rats and mice ran over my bed; but I was weary, and I slept such sleep as the wretched may, when a tempest has passed over them. Morning came. I knew it only by the noises I heard; for in my small den day and night were all the same.

ELLEN: You have to take me with, Grandmother said so.

BENNY: Aw, Grandmother, does Ellen have to go with me? Can't I go alone? Please?

GRANDMOTHER: Hush. Both of you hush. And hurry that soup over to Mrs. Bissel while it's still hot. Mind you, don't splash it.

NARRATOR: I heard the voices of my children. There was joy and there was sadness in the sound. It made my tears flow. How I longed to speak to them! I was eager to look on their faces; but there was no hole, no crack, through which I could peep. This continued darkness was oppressive.

My food was passed up to me through the trapdoor my uncle had contrived; and my Grandmother, my Uncle Phillip, and Aunt Nancy would seize such opportunities as they could, to mount up there and chat with me at the opening. But of course, this was not safe in the daytime. It must all be done in darkness. It was impossible for me to move in an erect position, but I crawled about my den for exercise. One day I hit my head against something, and found it was a gimlet. My uncle had left it sticking there when he made the trapdoor. I was as rejoiced as Robinson Crusoe could have been at finding such a treasure. It put a lucky thought into my head. I said to myself, "Now I will have some light. Now I will see my children." I did not dare to begin my work during the daytime, for fear of attracting attention. But I groped round; and having found the side next the street, where I could frequently see my children, I stuck the gimlet in and waited for evening. I bored three rows of holes, one above another; then I bored out the

interstices between. I thus succeeded in making one hole about an inch long and an inch broad. I sat by it till late into the night, to enjoy the little whiff of air that floated in. In the morning, I watched for my children. The first person I saw in the street was Dr. Flint. I had a shuddering, superstitious feeling that it was a bad omen. Several familiar faces passed by. At last, I heard the merry laugh of children, and presently two sweet little faces were looking up at me, as though they knew I was there, and were conscious of the joy they imparted. How I longed to tell them I was there!

My condition was now a little improved. The heat of my den was intense, for nothing but thin shingles protected me from the scorching summer's sun. But I had my consolations. through my peeping-hole I could watch the children, and when they were near enough, I could hear their talk.

One day, I saw Dr. Flint dressed for travel and headed toward the dock where I knew a steamboat offered passage north. Grandmother brought me the news.

GRANDMOTHER: Aunt Nancy says the doctor wrote to New York to a colored woman, born and raised in our neighborhood, and had breathed his contaminating atmosphere. He offered her a reward if she could find out anything about you. I know not what was the nature of her reply; but he has started for New York in haste, saying to his family that he had business of importance to transact.

NARRATOR: I peeped at him as he passed on his way to the steamboat. It was a satisfaction to have miles of land and water between us, even for a little while; and it was a still greater

satisfaction to know that he believed me to be in the Free States. He returned without obtaining any satisfactory information. When he passed our house, Benny, having heard talk that Dr. Flint had gone to find me, called out, and I heard the exchange.

BENNY: Dr. Flint, did you bring my mother home? I want to see her.

DR. FLINT: Get out of the way, you little damned rascal! If you don't, I'll cut off your head.

BENNY: You can't put me in jail again. I don't belong to you now.

NARRATOR: Still, it wasn't long days before Dr. Flint was back. Seeing Benny and Ellen playing in the garden, he stopped to speak to them.

DR. FLINT: Say, now, you see what I have here? Each of these is a whole silver dollar. One for each of you if you tell me what you've heard your grandmother say about your mother. We can use these to go buy some treats, bright new handkerchiefs, if you can tell me where your mother is.

BENNY: Dr. Flint, I don't know where my mother is. I guess she's in New York; and when you go there again, I wish you'd ask her to come home, for I want to see her; but if you put her in jail, or tell her you'll cut her head off, I'll tell her to go right back.

Autumn came, with a pleasant abatement of heat. My eyes had become accustomed to the dim light, and by holding my book or work in a certain position near the aperture I contrived to read and sew. That was a great relief to the tedious monotony of my life. But when winter came, the cold penetrated through the thin shingle roof, and I was dreadfully chilled. The winters there are not so long, or so severe, as in northern latitudes; but the houses are not built to shelter from cold, and my little den was peculiarly comfortless. The kind Grandmother brought me bedclothes and warm drinks. And one day, something more.

GRANDMOTHER: Here you are, Linda. I think you'll do well with these.

LINDA: So much material. Grandmother, what do you expect that I can do with this?

GRANDMOTHER: It will be Christmas soon enough. Benny and Ellen will need their stockings filled. I've measured them. Here, make Benny a suit and Ellen a dress. Some dolls and small animals. Edge some handkerchiefs.

NARRATOR: Benny and Ellen had their Christmas stockings filled. Their imprisoned mother could not have the privilege of witnessing their surprise and joy. But I had the pleasure of peeping at them as they went into the street with their new suits on. I heard Benny call out to a playmate.

BENNY: Say, did Santa bring you anything?

PLAYMATE: Yes. Sure. But Santa Claus ain't a real man. It's the children's mothers that put things in the stockings.

BENNY: No, that can't be, for Santa Claus brought Ellen and me these new clothes, and my mother has been gone this long time.

NARRATOR: How I longed to tell him that his mother made those garments, and that many a tear fell on them while she worked!

I would pass another six Christmases in my self-made prison. I would pass one more living as a fugitive slave in the free states of the north before I had Benny and Ellen with me again.

THE END